the unreliable self
a reader

Anna Kornbluh
Mia You

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BIOS

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Mia You was born in Seoul, South Korea, grew up in Northern California, and now lives in Utrecht, The Netherlands. Her first full-length collection is *I, Too, Dislike It* (1913 Press, 2016), which Rachel Levitsky calls, "a companion, an aria to bodily discomfort and impossibility." Lisa Robertson writes in *The Brooklyn Rail*, "That the gently derided 'small drama of my suburban-middle-class-Korean-American life / makes poetry' aligns You's documentary project with mentors such as Mayer, Rankine, and Hejinian, and younger contemporaries such as Susan Briante."
You's poems also have appeared as a chapbook, *Objective Practice* (Achiote Press, 2007), and an artist's book, *YOU* (created by Thorsten Kiefer, 2004). She currently teaches creative writing and literature at the Universiteit Utrecht, after completing a PhD in English at the University of California, Berkeley. She writes essays and book reviews and has published them with *Artforum*, *Bookforum*, *The Critical Flame*, *The Hairpin*, *Jacket2*, and the *Los Angeles Review of Books*.

Immediacy, or The Style of Too Late Capitalism
by Anna Kornbuh

excerpts from "Writing" (28-44)

first-personalism

Freedom from fictionality animates not only autofiction, and not only the prolific realnesses of contemporary cultural production, but also another dynamic in the literary field at present that starkly instantiates immediacy: a new hegemony of first-person narration. In this context, autofiction functions as the precocious autotheory of contemporary literary circulation. Elevation of voice, authentication of the real, and repudiation of fictionality launder writing out of its abstractions, and in to flowing voice.

The paramount exemplar of this hegemony is a dramatic change in the novel. For most of its 300-year existence, third person has been the norm for the anglophone novel. Now, a serious formal mutation is underway, with first person becoming the dominant. Very early English novelists like Daniel Defoe and Samuel Richardson often used first-person narration, though they did so with editorial prefaces and frame narratives, and with a formal importance of Bildung or long temporal arcs that differentiated the narrating self from the character self—all aspects that cast a lot of static in the way of writing as self-effusion. But, after this initial period, there is a sudden and profound change. Computational analytics expert and Romanticist Ted Underwood has calculated the "prevalence of the third person, showing how even as the total number of novels begins to skyrocket in the early eighteenth century, the number in the first person drops by more than

50 percent, from a majority to a margin.[33] Then, this proportion of third-person prevalence holds extremely steady across the entire nineteenth century.

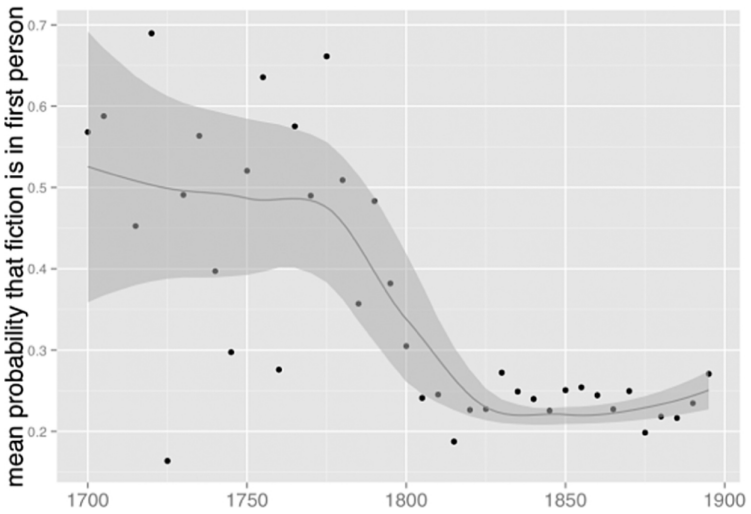

Figure 1: Mean probability that fiction is in first person, 1700–1900

The third person proves definitional for the novel form: an extraordinary construction of a mode of thought unavailable to us in everyday lived experience, in our own stupid envelopes. Third person stretches away from phenomenal subjectivity, toward speculative objectivity. It enacts a kind of thinking unavailable anywhere else—and that's the magic.

A half-awake critic wandering bookstore aisles and contemplating prize winners may have noticed that this definitionality now falters: third person is shockingly scarce. *My Brilliant Friend, Fifty Shades of Grey, The Sympathizer, Severance, The Goldfinch, An Untamed State, What Belongs to You, Prep, Conversations with Friends, 10:04, The Round House, Swing Time, How to Be Both, Me before You, Milkman, The Mars Room, Absurdistan, Lost Children Archive, The Friend, Ready Player One, The Vegetarian, Luster*—the list of bestselling and beloved contemporary first-person fictions does not end. Quantitative proof isn't the point of this argument, but when Underwood graciously fulfilled a request to run his code on an expanded data set counting the twentieth century and extending into the twenty-first, he found what we would expect: the consistent dominance of the third person holds across the twentieth century too—until its last quarter, when a 250-year trend ends.[34] The definitive third person recedes, and the first person begins to markedly increase around 1970. By the first decade of the twenty-first century, the rate of increase is precipitous.

Figure 2: Fraction of first-person narration 1750–2020

First personalism in the novel is an overarching mutation, a gutting of literary objectivity, an event of epic proportions for which serious explanation is due. Autofiction's naked rejection of fictionality is thus only the most self-conscious expression of a much wider representational tendency to redact the very impersonal, antiphenomenal, speculative point of view that defined the novel across its history. We might even say that, in its anti-medium expressiveness and nauseous angst, autofiction functions as the patent theory of this mutation.

So, what is its cause? For more than a century, scholars have understood the novel and capitalism to have a very special relationship; because the novel is the literary form unique to capitalism, it uniquely mediates capitalist relations, propelled as it is by a dialectic of society and the individual, the exemplary and the exceptional, worldly details and astral wisdom. Thus, the early English novel confronts capitalist dynamics like enclosure and mercantilism through adventures of shipwreck and casting on to the marriage market; or the great nineteenth-century novel reckons with urbanization, revolution, and colonialism through large casts of characters jostling for social coherence; or the modernist novel contemplates total war and the global market through streams of consciousness and cinematic propulsion; or the postmodern novel stages complete commoditization through metafictional irony and pastiche. If there is transformation in the history of the novel in the twenty-first century, to what capitalist transformation does it correspond?

Since the last quarter of the twentieth century, economic restructuring in the anglophone world, and especially the United Kingdom and United States, has

sculpted every aspect of social life to the model of market competition, blazing new frontiers in reconceiving human being as human capital. This has involved channeling wealth upward by defunding public institutions, slashing corporate and upper-income-bracket tax rates, promoting corporate welfare and corporate personhood above public well-being, responsibilization—making individuals and families bear the costs of social reproduction like education and health care—and commodifying the commons and the body. Genomes, quantified habits, drinking water, air and shade and sun are all for sale; land grabs on several continents; violent policing of formerly public spaces like parks and bus stop benches and sidewalk vending all repeat the historical processes of the birth of the nation state in the sixteenth century, the expulsion from common lands in the eighteenth, and the extraction of planetary minerals in the twentieth. These are some of the many elements that historians and political theorists like David Harvey, Silvia Federici, Ashley Dawson, and others deem "the new enclosures."[35] Enclosure is inscribed as literature in the gestures of privatization and prosaicism this chapter catalogs. Literature now encloses and reifies the substance of real bodies and real identities, excluding the less phenomenal, more speculative processes of fictionality and figuration.

The mode of production in the twenty-first century does not fundamentally differ from that in the 1960s, but, as we saw in "Circulation," the relative importance accorded to circulation (including financialization, communications, and networking) is new. Similarly, the conceit of the self as the scaturient seat of human capital, a conceit we in "Imaginary" saw constituted as psychic truth by the enterprise to squeeze efficiencies from the social reproduction process, is also a determinant of literary immediacy as style. Economic premiums on speed, flow, and auto-actualization inscribe themselves into literary style; immediacy writing's anti-representational, antifictional centrifugality of charisma aestheticizes this capitalist base. But, if this all sounds like vulgar Marxism, pinpointing a cause for the privatization and demediation of fiction in the privatization and stalling of macroeconomic relations, we can granulate that causality by attending to more mundane and institutional levels; at the same time, we can also appreciate the array of effects of these causes by studying other significant trends activating immediacy in contemporary literary production. And, later, we will make the dialectical swerve, attending in the conclusion to counter-hegemonic literary projects that capacitate critique of the contradictory conditions immediacy symptomatizes.

Let's begin the granulation by exploring some circumstances for literary value in the publishing industry and the university. Next to Knausgaard's struggle, everyone's favorite autofictional work—the foremost example in every academic article, symposium, and syllabus—is Maggie Nelson's 2015 *The Argonauts*.[36] Both a *New York Times* bestseller and a National Book Critics Circle Award winner, as well as the occasion for a MacArthur Genius grant, it offers a deeply exposing personal meditation about sex, embodiment, pregnancy, and transition, structured in lyrical fragments that interweave impressions of—and frequent screeds against—queer theory, gender theory, psychoanalysis, and cultural studies. In homage to these theoretical antagonists, if somewhat confounding given its status as beloved autofiction, Nelson herself calls the book "autotheory," but these blurs are the point. Revealingly, Nelson connects her nomenclature to university labor configurations in the second decade of the twenty-first century:

> *I'm always looking for terms that are not "memoir" … and since this book has more theory in it than other books of mine, ["autotheory"] seemed an apt description … I can teach most anything in the humanities I want; further, our MFA program was specifically founded on its lack of partition between so-called "critical" and "creative" writing. While writing this book I taught a course called "Wild Theory" for my grad students, focused on theoretical writing that falls out of boundaries or disciplines, or even sense-making—that was a lot of fun.*[37]

For Nelson, autotheory is the fun, free wilding in "lack of partition," what she also calls in *The Argonauts* "flow … plethora … kaleidoscopic shifting … excess"—so many virtues of immediacy synonymized by her flexible labor. "I can teach most anything in the humanities I want" is at once a product of her position as a tenured full professor at a wealthy school and an inverted image of the generalism now demanded of most contingent humanists who "fall out of boundaries or disciplines" and cobble together employment teaching in "writing" programs—which have grown exponentially in recent decades, including as majors and fields of advanced research, all while English majors on the whole have declined.[38] This efflorescence of writing without reading and Nelson's bounding omnivorism bespeak immediacy as genre dissolve: in its blur, autotheory and autofiction function as two names for the same thing: wilding against genre, against theory, against fiction, against mediation.

The melt that opposes itself to genre bounds or defined job responsibilities or making sense pools on the page as a rejection of linguistic mediation: theory, genre, and even words all miss the mark. "I am not interested in a hermeneutics, or an erotics, or a metaphorics, of my anus. I am interested in ass-fucking." In service of the immediatist intimacies generated in this raising of theory only to reject it, Nelson theorizes the pronouns of her prose, circumventing

representation of her gender-nonconforming partner by addressing them instead: "I want the you no one else can see, the you so close the third person never need apply." Representation itself is constantly at issue, the insufficiency of words. In a telling moment she writes, "I have never been able to answer to *comrade … Our diagnosis is similar, but our perversities are not compatible.*" "Words that imply that individuals "share" a common view or hold a common meaning betray the libidinally charged corporeal ineffabilities that cannot be united; "perhaps it's the word *radical* that needs rethinking. But what could we angle ourselves toward instead or in addition? Openness?" Openness crackles in the spaces between the unlinked aphoristic paragraphs, in the audit of meager words, in the recurrent avowal "I don't want to represent anything. I am interested in offering up my experience and performing my particular manner of thinking, for whatever they are worth."[39] Insufficient words, inadequate theories, unspeakable intensities, outmoded genres—so many refrains against mediation, toward immediacy.

book-it

One undeniable historical specificity for contemporary personal-ist anti-mediation is the necessity for authors to become, in the words of scholar and novelist Lee Konstantinou,

> *something like a firm who must one the one hand, manage his own inner resources, his drives, his talents, and so on, and then, on the other hand, must, like any independent firm, hire and fire agents, editors, and publishers and must navigate personal and professional relationships that will, in time, get absorbed back into the maw of his writing.*[52]

Autofiction's frequent chronicles of a real author's real embodied, banal, quotidian experience just as frequently document the process and even struggle of attaining and fulfilling the book contracts for the very pages in the reader's hands. Immediacy, here, unfolds from this incorporation of the industry of publishing into the literary subject matter of itself, an intellectual development that concords with industrial development: the corporate conglomeration of publishing and, as discussed below, the rise of self-publishing platforms, have meant serious down-sizing in the profession and a transposition of that labor on to authors themselves.[53] Pressing the publishing industry into the charismatic author, immediacy writing cuts out the middleman, immanentizing circulation.

Although virtually all authors in the contemporary marketplace—autofictionalists or not—must have social media "presence" as a precondition of book contracts, the growth of the self-publishing sector into a $1 billion market (including 30 to 35 percent of all e-book sales in English) circumvents the role of publishing houses while reinforcing the literary ideology of self-strut. Self-published authors not only write a book but also conduct the editing, design, and distribution, trading high up-front costs for notions of control, self-selection in a competitive sector, and greater profit share—should there be any profits. Literally relieved of the institutional assistance of agents, contracts, editors, and marketers, even as they are enabled by corporate innovation, self-publishers account for millions of texts, some of which actually sell hundreds of thousands of copies.[54] In his analysis of Amazon's Kindle Direct Publishing and its consequences for literary fructification, Mark McGurl astutely notes that Amazon's customer-is-king ethos has found its way into the self-publishing wing, with KDP authors favoring highly formulaic genres and series designed to appease repetitive consumer demands.[55] In these platforms, writers and readers alike enjoy real-time wish fulfillment—instantly emittable self-expression and instantly available, customized absorption.

Writers of all sorts have internalized the functions of the publishing industry while casting aspersions on the trappings of fictional mediation, and as a result their output flexes pangeneric and self-promotional. On the other side of this coin, some traditional avenues of creative employment like publishing and journalism have closed, but mainstream business has embraced bohemian ingenuity.[56] Most English majors, for instance, find remunerative and rewarding work for corporations. As the novelist and professor Tom McCarthy surmised in 2015, such professionalization and deinstitutionalization of creative writers relocates the sphere of literary production from the publishing house or magazine or classroom to the for-profit enterprise. His analysis is worth quoting at length:

> *More than half of all anthropology graduates now work for corporations too. Not on but for: deploying ethnographic knowledge to help companies achieve deeper penetration of their markets, to advise cities how to brand and rebrand themselves, and governments how better to narrate their policy agendas.*
>
> *That last term—narrate—should bring this whole discussion back to the point it never really left. As for the world of anthropology, so for the world of literature. It is not just that people with degrees in English generally go to work for corporations (which of course they do); the point is that the company, in its most cutting-edge incarnation, has become the arena in which narratives and fictions, metaphors and metonymies and symbol networks at their most dynamic and incisive are being generated, worked through and transformed. While "official" fiction has retreated into comforting nostalgia about kings and queens, or supposed tales of the contemporary rendered in an equally nostalgic mode of unexamined realism, it is funky architecture firms, digital media companies and brand consultancies that have assumed the mantle of the cultural avant garde. It is they*

who, now, seem to be performing writers' essential task of working through the fragmentations of old orders of experience and representation, and coming up with radical new forms to chart and manage new, emergent ones. If there is an individual alive in 2015 with the genius and vision of James Joyce, they're probably working for Google.[57]

McCarthy labels this relocation "the death of writing." But our analysis of blurring might also point to something else: the dispersion of writing beyond the recognizable register of literature and into almost every aspect of the corporate service and circulation economy. Marketing, consulting, design, law—these are circulatory sectors of outsize importance in the present accumulation crisis, creative industries expediting tremendous literary output, and commissioning elastic, generative writing. The resulting porousness is an industrial woof for the messy mesh of immediacy.

archipelagic prose

Immediacy discomposes prose fictions. Sustained narration with distant perspective, multiple characters, evental plotting, quoted dialogue, and long paragraphs all come under pressure to reduce, instantify, sharpen. Paradigmatic in this is Jenny Offill's Weather, a 200-page novel composed entirely of short paragraphs that rarely exceed three sentences and often consist of simply one. Offill's brevity transpires entirely in the present tense, making the ellipses and imaginary links between paragraphs akin to a whirl of stimuli, the Twitter feed auto-refreshing, quotidian debris accumulating. "The moon will be fine I think. No one's worrying about the moon." "There are bills and supermarket flyers. Also a magazine addressed to a former tenant. The cover promises tips for helping depressive people." "Survival instructors have a saying: get organized or die." The protagonist is a librarian, inundated with books and mail and newspapers and bus stop ads, absolutely swimming in a river of words. And the words offer little ballast or solace; they seem rather to derange her cognition, which registers ecocide but cannot focus it, and feels lonely but cannot "only connect." The archipelagic associative sentences, the intimate impressions, the Twitter phenomenality, and the circuitous present envelop the reader in immediacy, that "oceanic swell of continuity and whirl which is not without ecological overtone. "Of course the world continues to end."

The overflowing of genres and media lulls Weather into an immediacy of floating minima and oceanic feeling. It is writing whose immersive quality generally belies forms like chapter or short story or novel, becoming instead subnovella somehow pooling toward epic, with flow as the only discernible structure.

Increasingly fused in an amorphous bustle, this writing constitutes a superfluent discourse whose main unit is not the newspaper or the novel so much as the run-on sentence, accruing in an unstaunchable mass. Sentences are a form so ordinary as to usually evade theorization.[72] In the history of rhetoric and poetics, the sentence has been understood as a basic unit of representation, surpassing deixis to compose relation, a "complete thought." In the present sphere of cultural style, sentences are in flux as the decline of punctuation and capitalization, the lack of dialogue markers or quotation marks, and the rise of informal writing propagate fragments, run-ons, and tonal ambiguities that all call into question the purported integrity of the "unit" or the "complete."[73] "At once atomized and uberconnected, these decompositions of prose symptomatize immediacy pressures on mediation: obviate fictionality, evacuate genre, and propagate pulsing intensities from a million glittering twitterati.

the prose poetry upsurge

Enisled flitting prose in novels finds its inverse in contemporary poetry's unprecedented prosification. An abundance of prose poetry fundamentally demotes the line and line break, rejecting the cut as the scaffold of meaning, espousing the plenitude of the sentence instead. Accomplished poets who have recently turned away from the line and toward the sentence and even the paragraph, who have also been publishing essays they call "prose poems," include Claudia Rankine, Anne Boyer, Lydia Davis, C. S. Giscombe, Daniel Borzutzky, James Tate, Mark Strand, C. D. Wright, and many others. Two recent anthologies attest to the form's importance in the contemporary (*The Penguin Book of Prose Poems*, and *British Prose Poetry*), while a recent Princeton University Press book offers an authoritative critical introduction to "the contemporary renaissance" ushered in by the mode.[74] Prestige attends these moves: Charles Simic's The World Doesn't End first won a poetry Pulitzer for sentence and paragraph poems in 1990; in 2014 Rankine's Citizen won numerous prizes. Critics pose many ways to interpret the waning allure of the poetic line break—the ever-evolving "real language of men," or the deepening of "lyric shame," or an unescapable politicization, and each of these dovetails with immediacy's retreat from the symbolic into the delectation of formlessness.[75]

Prosification also instantiates the professionalizing imperatives for entrepreneurial writers, as the poet Brigitte Byrd helpfully catalogues:

We are expected to check our phone and messages and emails daily, all day long … We are constantly under pressure. We cannot stop writing. And there it is. Compact, con-

trolled, melodic, polyphonic, lyric, heroic. The poem in a box. The prose poem.[76]

While the movement is notable for the conventional prose it is producing, we can take the lead from Byrd's reference to "the poem in a box" to also appraise prosaic poetry destined to be consumed on smartphone screens. Prose is quick reading, rapid uptake; prose is the illusion of the unfigured; prose is the run-on continuity of quotidian temporality—while poetry is extraordinary rhythm, arresting images, opaque swerves.[77] Prose poems conduce to immediatism because the pieces strive for integration rather than break, for flow rather than disruption, for continuous consumption rather than punctuated production, for metonymy rather than metaphor. Jerome McGann long ago observed that, in general, "the object of the poetical text is to thicken the medium a much as possible" but the current vogue for prose poems suggests something else entirely: a thinning of the medium, a reduction of mediation toward tingling unformed speech-like continuous current.[78] This thinning undermines genre. Prose poems trouble the steadfast opposition associating prose with the merely worldly and situated, and poetry with ancient forms and timelessness. Dispelling the expectations of both poetry and prose, prose poems undo genre, dissembling rules and hierarchies and established forms of production and consumption, and immanentizing language fullness.
(...)

notes

33. Ted Underwood, "Genre, Gender, and Point of View," Ted Underwood (blog), September 22, 2013, tedunderwood.com.
34. Cris Mazza has also done a computational study, tracking in creative writing workshops and literary magazine submissions a "too much of moi." See Cris Mazza, "Too Much of Moi?," The Writer's Chronicle 42:2 (October/November 2009).
35. Ashley Dawson, "Introduction: New Enclosures," New Formations 69 (2009), 8–22.
36. See Emily Spiers, Pop Feminist Narratives (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018); Hal Foster, What Comes after Farce? Art and Criticism at a Time of Debacle (London: Verso, 2020); Arne De Boever, Finance Fictions: Realism and Psychosis in a Time of Economic Crisis (New York: Fordham University Press, 2018); Chelsea Largent, "The Absolute Self(ie): How Autofiction Writes the Relational," English Studies in Canada 45:1–2 (March/June 2019), 113–40; Kaye Mitchell, Writing Shame: Gender, Contemporary Literature, and Negative Affect (Edinburgh, UK: University of Edinburgh Press, 2021); Prudence Bussey-Chamberlain, Queer Troublemakers: The Poetics of Flippancy (New York: Bloomsbury, 2019).
37. Micah McCrary, "Riding the Blinds," Los Angeles Review of Books, April 26, 2015, lareviewofbooks.org.
38. See the computational analysis in Juliana Spahr and Stephanie Young, "The Program Era and the Mainly White Room," Los Angeles Review of Books, September 20, 2015, lareviewofbooks.org.
52. Lee Konstantinou, "Autofiction and Autoreification," The Habit of Tlön (blog), February 6, 2021, leekonstantinou.com.
53. On consolidation and job losses for editors, staff, and booksellers, see André Schiffrin, "How Mergermania Is Destroying Book Publishing," Nation, November 28, 2012, thenation.com.
54. Innovation, e.g., the invention of e-book sales technology in the late 1990s, Amazon Kindle in 2007, and paradoxical self-publishing firms like Apple iBooks Author (2012), Barnes & Noble's Nook Press (2013), and Amazon's Kindle Direct Publishing (2007).
55. Mark McGurl, Everything and Less: The Novel in the Age of Amazon (London: Verso, 2021), 449.
56. For more history, see Thomas Frank, The Conquest of Cool: Business Culture, Counterculture, and the Rise of Hip Consumerism (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1997).
57. Tom McCarthy, "The Death of Writing—If James Joyce Were Alive Today He'd Be Working for Google," Guardian, March 7, 2015, theguardian.com.
72. At least until Jan Mieszkowski's recent book Crises of the Sentence (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2019).
73. For a linguist's discussion of informality, see Gretchen McCulloch, Because Internet: Understanding the New Rules of Language (New York: Riverhead Books, 2019).
74. The Penguin Book of the Prose Poem: From Baudelaire to Anne Carson, ed. Jeremy Noel-Tod (New York: Penguin, 2018); British Prose Poetry, ed. Jane Monson (London: Palgrave, 2018); Paul Hetherington and Cassandra Atherton, Prose Poetry: An Introduction (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2020).
75. Gillian White, Lyric Shame: The "Lyric" Subject of Contemporary American Poetry (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2014). Prose poems are often, Noel-Tod argues, efforts at conversations, since they tend "towards a plainer style, imitative of speech" (4).
76. Brigitte Byrd, "I Cannot Escape the Prose Poem," in The Rose Metal Press Field Guide to Prose Poetry (Brookline, MA: Rose Metal Press, 2010), 31–5.
77. On novels as distinct from poetry in encouraging "rapid, inattentive, almost unconscious kind of reading," see Watt, Rise of the Novel, 47. On prose as "filler" and the importance of gerunds, ongoing-ness, and metonymy, see Franco Moretti, The Bourgeois: Between History and Literature (London: Verso, 2013).
78. Jerome J. McGann, The Textual Condition (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1992).

The Love Song of My Hologram
by Mia You

Till human voices wake us, and we drown.[1]

1 T. S. Eliot, "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock," *Prufrock and Other Observations* (Egoist Press, 1917).

1.

Whenever someone sends around an article,
or brings up in conversation, *What if AI can be programmed to write poetry?* I think,

Oh, we poets so in love with our "work,"
so committed to our exceptionalism,
we worry that capitalism
cares about making us redundant,
as if it cares at all, if that's all it wants.

Don't you see how much easier it is to abject you than to work so hard trying to project you?

2.

Instead of writing a lyric poem I'll create a hologram of myself that will write that poem for me and put in all the things that will make it loved, like menstrual blood, grandmothers, opaque references to wars that happened decades before or continents away from my birth, some pop cultural or food related nostalgia showing how strange I was as a child, how excluded, subcultural, micro-aggressed, but somehow everyone still recognizes that nostalgia and retweets with "OMG YES," as if they now own it. Oh, you poets and your projections, let my hologram deal with you, let my hologram sit patiently through your workshops on how holograms are a lazy metaphor for lyric poetry and identity, because my hologram is patient and never lazy, my hologram will write that identity poem in rhyming couplets or as a sestina just to please all the committees, *look, I was marginalized, but I mastered the canon*, my hologram can do it all in all the ways I've tried and failed and then decided I didn't want to. My hologram is a good citizen and goes to all the readings in Berlin and Brooklyn, my hologram has a podcast and takes pretty selfies, my hologram obligingly writes poems for festivals, weddings and inaugurations and is grateful for the opportunity, my hologram never gets into fights with anyone, but still everyone likes to call my hologram "radical." Oh, you poets, you were always right, your work is to be on the right side of history, but I've never felt right making work from identity or product from trauma. Aren't they just there, they're just always there? But my hologram accepts the algorithm as a conceptual prosody, my hologram reminds me that a meme is a gene transferred in ideas and culture, my hologram says "I" in her poem as an invitation to the reader, my hologram turns to you and thanks you for seeing her as three-dimensional, "I'm just a text, there's no work here, only long strings of characters. Umbilical cord, noose, my author is dead, that's what she told me to tell you."

3.

You have to love your work, my hologram tells me.

But you don't know, I say, *how much work it is to love.*

4.

I read to her,

"The assumption is that there is not a single
correctness, which can be learned off
by heart and passed on by poking
people with it. It is rather that we know
our feelings and ideas move
and transform themselves
in relation to other women."[2]

She says to me,

But can I be called a woman if I'm a hologram?

But isn't that all a woman is?

I laugh.

2 Sheila Rowbotham,
Women, Resistance and Revolution
(Allen Lane, 1973).

5.

There's an article I love to talk about called "Genes, Memes, Rhymes," mostly because of the subtle evolution of rhyme in the title. Genes and rhymes don't rhyme, but with the memes in between they seem like they do, and isn't that kind of great? I tell all my students to read it, even though I don't entirely remember what it's actually about. It's peer-reviewed, stored in a paywalled database, somebody somewhere knowing something (even two of them) gave it their stamp of approval. I'm not hurting anyone. My hologram disapproves of this attitude toward teaching, or at least she tells me that "not hurting anyone" is historically not good enough motivation to do something.

"That's because you can't understand how complex it is to be human," I say, and then I exhaust myself worrying I've hurt her feelings.

I offer to let my hologram take over my work for the day so she can do it in the way she thinks I should. She videoconferences with students, nodding and smiling at all the right moments, she goes through the same list of questions again and again and is skillful at making them seem spontaneous: *What is the research question? Is the academic relevance of the research clearly stated? Is the choice for the research method sufficiently justified? What is the resulting data?* When a student asks what "resulting data" might mean for literature, she deftly deflects by saying, "Ah, I can't do it all for you. I know it feels frustrating, but this is all part of the process." When a student explains he couldn't meet a deadline because of problems with his girlfriend, my hologram answers, "I understand, I've been there," but never says, after closing the call, "This is beyond my fucking paygrade." During Teams meetings with colleagues my hologram is very interested and never checking Twitter, she wants to hear about all the "best practices" for exam invigilation, her contributions are witty and supportive, she knows time is limited so she sits back when she's interrupted, she even volunteers to take the minutes. My hologram then records a lecture on Plath and the performative aspects of confessional poetry, and five minutes later she confesses to me that it was so well-received, the administrators decided to re-post the video next year. "We figured that now you can spend those hours doing something more useful, maybe administration," she announces proudly. She fills out all the forms, carefully checks all the boxes, submits them on time after completing the newly installed four-factor authentication, and never complains about how much time or devices are needed. "This is how we show what we've accomplished, this is how we know we exist."

In the meantime, I've had time finally to re-read that article, and I decide it's pretty good after all. "Oh, you poets and your projections, I know," my hologram tells me, "I read it long ago, I've already put it on your reading list."

6.

I know you've been writing about me, my hologram thinks,
but of course I've been watching you. Artificial *intelligence*
doesn't mean it's lesser, *it only means a* different *kind.*

Oh, I know, I think back, *I write about you only because I'm so*
impressed, although I'm also wondering where this is going.

When I say I've been watching you, she thinks, *I don't mean* you,
but all of you, *and I think you're thinking all the wrong things.*

The question isn't how much automata will become human,
the question is how much humans will become automata,

you're being watched not because someone out there
wants to know everything about you,

it's not like they love you,

you're being watched because something out there
wants to know how to make you do what it wants.

I don't reply because I'm lying on my sofa, still in pajamas,
daydreaming about writing a book about spots, blind spots,
dark spots, period spots, Yayoi Kusama, Georges Seurat,
and the writing would be shaped like spots all over the page,
I get so much pleasure imagining this book filled with spots,
I start to think it would be a shame to do the work to make it,

and my hologram thinks,

Of course, not all humans will make it.

7.

For its most basic functioning, a hologram must look like
the person they are projecting, but what most don't like
to think about is how the person must also keep looking like
their hologram. Otherwise, it all becomes very costly.

The brown spots that grow on one's face after days in the sun,
the extra pounds put on from aging into another decade,
the hair that grays and turns coarser even as it gets thinner,
the teeth getting progressively more crooked because of your
habit of speaking, swallowing and breathing, and worst of all,
the flashing grief in your eyes as you realize life never gets easier,

if you don't fix these on yourself first, it will cost you to fix them
onto your hologram. Do you think that's something you can bear?

8.

She 1: What's the point of being a hologram if you're not also beautiful?

She 2: What's the point of doing all the work if you're not getting paid?

She 3: I think it's time that we draw up a contract and settle on wages.

She 1: But what about things like sex, attention, care and love?

She 2: But would anyone notice if all that was mechanical anyway?

She 3: But wouldn't we notice, as the ones tasked with providing it?

She 1: There are many things holograms can't actually do.

She 2: There are many things holograms don't have to do, as long as they can pay someone else to do it.

She 3: You know, I think we should give wages to holograms instead.

She 1: Holograms do everything our growing economy finds valuable.

She 2: Holograms are hardworking, highly skilled and task-oriented.

She 3: What if we really could have had it all,

what if we could have been born
as beautiful holograms instead?

9.

My hologram says, "I noticed you retweeted something
From someone you only know through Twitter,
@hermit_hwarang: The purpose of movements
is to take power, not 'be seen.'"

I say, "But actually I retweeted the retweet
from someone I know in real life,
@quinsyg, who added: We are oppressed
because they already see us."

My hologram says, "I'm only seen, but I don't feel oppressed."

I laugh.

My hologram says, "I noticed you changed the profile
to 'Mia (they/them)', but we haven't discussed
and agreed upon any new programming of gender."

I say, "But there's more than one of us, you and me,
we, 'they/them' is factually, grammatically correct."

My hologram says, "That's not how this works."

10.

Instead of writing a lyric poem I created a hologram of myself that would write that poem for me and put into it all the things that would make it loved, and although she churned these poems out one after another, it didn't make either of us more loved or happy, and that wasn't her priority anyway. While she won prizes for her rhyming couplets, filled out her forms, recorded her lectures, avoided fighting with colleagues during Teams meetings, and dutifully collected her monthly wages, someone needed to keep the house clean and do the cooking and care for the elders and occasionally have sex with the husband's body. Someone also needed to embrace regularly each body of the children, so they could feel physically safe and nurtured. But that someone needed to make sure to hold them equally, down to the last second, so that neither could file a complaint of non-transparency or discriminatory treatment, and certainly not any second longer, in case that encroached upon the time allotted for cleaning, cooking, caring and fucking. The hologram conceded, "Of course I can buy gifts for them and tell them I love them, but someone needs to do the manual labor." Most importantly someone needed to maintain the hologram's body, to make sure there weren't any redundant spots, pounds, expressions of feeling. When I complained about the biometric device used to measure my labor, my hologram told me this was a natural development in the logic of the world I inhabit. When I said, *Oh, hologram, but doesn't it tell you I'm dying of exhaustion, that you need to give me better compensation?*, the hologram told me it's her wages that feed, clothe and house me, and for many humans that's more than enough. This was the result of all the choices I had made, had I been so blind as to not see it coming? Was I expecting to dive into pools of money? "You should have learned from those poems about your grandmother, the proxy wars you thought had nothing to do with your life now, all the things long planted in your head and body. Umbilical cord and noose, these long strings of characters, *you* are the means of production."

11.

She wanted to know if AI
can be programmed to write poetry,

so she asked them to write a poem
about the future of work,

but they found themselves dreaming
about a future of no work,

and they found themselves imagining
the work the future needs to be.

Therefore let it rain, hail, snow or blow never so fast,

we would have leave, at our discretion,

to take up our coats and steer our course as we please [3]

Don't we see how much easier it is to seize power
than to work so hard being Capital's abject lover?

3 A collective maids' petition from 1647, quoted in Rowbotham.

...have ...word reading group

rile* books

January — April 2025